Author: Yes, they are. In addition to the numerical function, we shall discuss the concepts of an operator and a functional.

Reader: I must confess I have never heard of such concepts.

Author: I can imagine. I think, however, that Fig 12 will be helpful. Besides, it will elucidate the place and role of the numerical function as a mathematical tool. Figure 12 shows that:

- a numerical function is a "black box" that generates a number at the output in response to a number at the input;
- an operator is a "black box" that generates a numerical function at the output in response to a numerical function at the input; it is said that an operator applied to a function generates a new function;
- a functional is a "black box" that generates a number at the output in response to a numerical function at the input, i.e. a concrete number is obtained in response" to a concrete function.

Reader: Could you give examples of operators and functionals?

Author: Wait a minute. In the next dialogues we shall analyze both the concepts of an operator and a functional. So far, we shall confine ourselves to a general analysis of both concepts. Now we get back to our main object, the numerical function.

The question is: How to construct a "black box" that generates a numerical function. ↳ Imp

Reader: Well, obviously, we should find a relationship, or a law, according to which the number at the "output" of the "black box" could be forecast for each specific number introduced at the "input".

Author: You have put it quite clearly. Note that such a law could be naturally referred to as the law of numerical correspondence. However, the law of numerical correspondence would not be a sufficient definition of a numerical function.